

The significance of economic factors to media industries and their products

- Alongside the increasingly global nature of television there has been a rise in the number of international co-productions. These are attractive as the collaboration means that economic responsibility can be shared and the more contributors, the bigger the production budget.
- The way in which a programme is funded can influence production, for example to qualify for funding production companies usually have to guarantee that they will film in a particular location, employ crew members from a particular country (both Swedish and Danish crews were employed in the production of *The Bridge*) and work in collaboration with other international companies.
- *The Bridge* was co-produced by Filmance International, an independent Swedish production company and by the Danish company Nimbus Film. It also received financial support from European public service broadcasters.
- The third season of *The Bridge* also received funding from:
 - The Copenhagen Film Fund. This co-funding resulted in more Danish crew members being employed on the third season than on the previous two because of the financial support of the CFF.
 - €1 million grant was received from Creative Europe MEDIA for Series 3 and helped to support and maintain the programme's high production values. Creative Europe provide financial backing for high quality, high budget European TV drama series.

Theoretical Approaches

Cultural Industries: Hesmondhalgh

- Whilst the BBC as a public service broadcaster is not under the same pressure as commercial broadcasters in terms of ratings and competition, it still uses a range of strategies to minimise risk and maximise audiences. One of these as indicated by Hesmondhalgh, is vertical integration. *The Bridge* was a Swedish/Danish co-production, received funding from several production companies and was distributed globally by ZDF Enterprises (a subsidiary of ZDF, Germany's national public television broadcaster).
- Another key strategy used by the BBC is formatting their cultural products. Where audiences can anticipate what to expect from new products through, for example familiarity with genre conventions, then the risk is minimised. In the UK, *The Bridge* was part of the Nordic Noir

branding; trailers employed the marketing strategy of grouping together programmes under this new brand, including *The Bridge*, *Borgen*, *The Killing* and *Wallander*, describing 'A world of flawed heroes and dark criminal minds' ('Nordic Noir & Beyond Trailer' <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=paEDB-337eA>). This enabled audiences to anticipate what to expect and used inheritance from previous examples of the genre to maximise audiences. Whilst containing an enigmatic narratives and complex, challenging characters, *The Bridge* also contains typical codes and conventions of a crime drama. Once the programme was established, the marketing materials used the recognisable characters, setting and iconic opening soundtrack to engage with audiences.

PART 4: STARTING POINTS – Audiences

How media products target, attract, reach, address and potentially construct audiences

- The programme attracts the more niche, less mainstream BBC Four audience who are targeted through their expectations based on the brand identity of the channel. In broadcasting Nordic Noir, BBC Four established that sub-titled stories could reach a British audience. 'BBC Four's primary role is to reflect a range of UK and international arts, music and culture. It should provide an ambitious range of innovative, high quality programming that is intellectually and culturally enriching' (www.bbc.co.uk).
- The programme may attract an inherited audience who will be familiar with other Nordic Noir dramas broadcast on this channel, for example *The Killing* and *Wallander*.
- *The Bridge* also offers a range of pleasures for the fans of crime drama (Uses and Gratifications theory), the programme has typical codes and conventions of crime dramas but an element of escapism and diversion through the different characters, setting and culture. Audiences will gain pleasure from following the investigators as they attempt to solve the crime.
- Loyal audiences will have become familiar with the character of Saga, this is the start of Series 3 and they will have expectations of how her character will behave and may develop based on the other series.

The way in which different audience interpretations reflect social cultural and historical circumstances

This may include:

- Different demographic factors, for example nationality. The programme constructs an idea of the cultural differences between Sweden and